SIGNAL REPORT

The AI-powered marketing *machine*.

AI did not kill marketing. It exposed the plumbing. How search, paid, and content became one signal system, and what to build now.

2026 · A FIELD REPORT FROM FRDTLAB · ADAPTED FROM THE SMX ADVANCED KEYNOTE

AI exposed the *plumbing*.

The brands winning right now are not running better campaigns. They are running better infrastructure.

For twenty years we organized marketing by channel. SEO over here, paid over there, social, email, PR, merchant, each in its own login with its own team and its own quarterly excuse. A disconnected stack turns every report into archaeology and every optimization into a negotiation.

AI did not kill that model. It exposed it. Plenty of brands found out their taxonomy was broken the day an AI summary got their product wrong. The work did not change. The visibility of the work changed. The advantage moved from channel expertise to infrastructure fluency.

People see channels. Machines see relationships. This report is the short version of how the new system works, and what to do about it.

AI doesn't rank content. It calculates *confidence*.

This is the whole shift in one idea, and it reorganizes everything downstream.

SEO THINKS

Page → Ranking → Click.

PPC THINKS

Ad → Click → Conversion.

AI ACTUALLY THINKS

Signal → Confidence → Recommendation.

The model is not ranking a page. It is scoring an entity. Have I seen this brand? How often? Across how many ecosystems? Is it described consistently? Does it solve the problem? The output is a confidence score, not a ranking. So stop optimizing pages and start increasing confidence. Every mention, review, citation, and conversion is a vote.

One intent, distributed *everywhere*.

Search is no longer one destination. The same buyer with the same intent now moves across Google, TikTok, ChatGPT, YouTube, Reddit, Shopping, Instagram, Perplexity, and Gemini, choosing a different surface every time.

The question stopped being how do I rank. The question is now whether your intent is covered everywhere the decision actually happens. This is the shift from search to intercept: you are not waiting at one door, you are present across every surface where the buyer is already deciding.

Most visibility happens where you aren't *looking*.

Marketers manage the tip of the iceberg. Machines read everything underneath it, and the job now is making the underwater part legible.

WHAT MARKETERS SEE

SEO. PPC. Social. Content. Email. PR. The visible channels, above the water line.

WHAT MACHINES SEE

Entities. Taxonomy. Product data. Reviews. Knowledge graphs. Audience signals. Conversions. Customer behavior. Structured data. Brand mentions. Signal reinforcement. **The whole submerged mass that actually decides the recommendation.**

Five failure points show up *fast*.

Every team has some version of these. Naming them is the first relief.

ONE	**Intent gaps**	Paid and organic answer different buyer questions.
TWO	**Taxonomy debt**	Products categorized by internal logic, not customer language.
THREE	**Slow loops**	Insights sit in decks instead of feeding the next action.
FOUR	**Measurement drama**	Clicks get reported while business impact stays fuzzy.
FIVE	**AI invisibility**	Models cannot retrieve what they cannot understand.

Organic earns memory. Paid buys learning *speed*.

The question was never SEO or paid. It is what this decision moment needs.

ORGANIC

Builds entity clarity and long-tail coverage. Earns authority and durable answers. Wins the citation in AI summaries.

PAID

Tests language and exposes conversion gaps. Intercepts the white space organic cannot reach yet. Forces prioritization with fast feedback.

Run them as one system and every dollar of paid learning makes the next organic decision cheaper.

Six layers, one *machine*.

Search, paid, and social are not separate programs. They are training the same intelligence machine.
The work is making each layer legible to humans and to models.

01	**Search mapping**	Stop mapping keywords. Map decisions. Problem, category, compatibility, purchase.
02	**Product**	The catalog, restructured around how customers actually search, not internal naming.
03	**Audience intelligence**	Raw signals in, structured intelligence out. Every segment labeled and organized.
04	**AI / LLM**	Built for the exact question a model will ask. Not machine-readable means not in the answer.
05	**Automation**	The agentic workflow that replaces five teams emailing each other reports.
06	**Velocity**	Content at volume becomes search signal, training data, retargeting, and authority at once.

The first 30 characters have a *job*.

This is where the abstract gets concrete. A title written for your catalog and a title written for how a human searches are not the same sentence, and only one of them gets retrieved.

CATALOG-FIRST

"Adjustable aluminum and vinyl door bottom sweep with drip cap." Technically accurate. Searches for nothing.

SEARCH-INTENT-FIRST

"22x36 9-Lite Door Glass, Fits the Frame, Stops Drafts." **The first 30 characters carry size, type, compatibility, and the problem solved.**

Customers search by the size of the hole in their door, not your SKU. When the catalog only speaks internal language and the customer only speaks the problem, the gap between them is exactly where the money leaks out.

The full fix, lever by lever, is in **Get Recommended by AI: The GEO Playboo** → frdtlab.com/geo-playbook

One loop. Five moves. Zero *silos*.

This is the operating model that replaces the disconnected stack. Every output trains the next cycle.

SENSE	SERPs, search terms, reviews, social, feed errors.
STRUCTURE	Entities, schema, clean naming, feed attributes.
SHIP	SEO pages, ad groups, feed fixes, FAQ answers.
MEASURE	Coverage, retrieval, conversion impact.
COMPOUND	Every output trains the next cycle.

One research pass feeds five channel outputs. Find the gap once, and it becomes a page, a feed title, ad copy, an FAQ, and AI retrieval all at the same time.

Volume stops being content and becomes *infrastructure*.

Six thousand videos is not a content plan. At volume, content quietly becomes five things at once: search signal you can suddenly answer, audience training that teaches the algorithm who you are for, AI training data that models ingest, a retargeting asset where every view becomes an audience, and semantic authority where you own the topic instead of one post.

FROM THE KEYNOTE STAGE

"We are no longer marketing on top of the system. We are marketing through it."

AMANDA FRIEDT · SMX ADVANCED

THE PROOF

Same products. Same budget. Different *infrastructure*.

A home-improvement e-commerce catalog, rebuilt as a signal system. It started at a feed score of 28 out of 100, with 43 percent of products disapproved and seven trackers triple-counting every sale. The foundation was not real. Here is what changed once the infrastructure did.

83.43%
Search visibility, up from 28.51%

+54.9 pts
Visibility gain in one quarter

+16.7%
Revenue, Apr 9 to Jun 8

+16.4%
Orders, same window

+22.1%
Visitors, same window

+408%
Organic Shopping purchases

−91%
Product disapprovals, 43% to ~4%

+110%
Feed score, 28 to 59

Want to know where your brand stands against these numbers? **Take the free 2-minute AI Visibility Scorecard**
→ frdtlab.com/scorecard

About one hundred dollars a month. Zero extra on *ads*.

The whole system above was automated for roughly a hundred dollars a month, with zero additional ad spend. The same playbook moved a luxury marine brand with eight-million-dollar inventory: a 3.3 percent conversion lift on listings most people would call unsellable online.

The barrier was never budget. It was structure. Most teams are one clean feed layer away from numbers like these.

From traffic to *confidence*.

TRAFFIC	→	**CONFIDENCE**
CHANNELS	→	**SYSTEMS**
RANKINGS	→	**RECOMMENDATIONS**
KEYWORDS	→	**ENTITIES**
CONTENT CREATION	→	**SIGNAL CREATION**
OPTIMIZATION	→	**LEARNING**
VISIBILITY	→	**TRUST**

Signal, decision, action. No 47-slide *readout*.

The cadence is what makes it a system instead of a campaign.

THE WEEKLY SIGNAL STANDUP

What changed? Search terms, SERPs, AI answers, feed errors. What did we learn? Which signal moved the next decision. What do we ship? **One fix, one asset, one paid test.**

THE 30-DAY ROLLOUT

Week one, map decisions and query gaps. Week two, fix taxonomy, feed, and landing friction. Week three, launch paid tests and AI-answer assets. Week four, build the feedback loop and the scorecard.

IN CLOSING

Monday morning: start with the *human*.

Do not build the whole architecture at once. Find the one place where your customers' language and your structure do not match. Fix that title, feed, or page first. Ship one structural fix this week. Then build the loop, one fix, one asset, one test, and repeat.

The shift underneath all of it: AI does not discover brands. It gains confidence in them. A mediocre brand with consistent naming, reviews, taxonomy, and feed structure beats brilliant content with weak structure, almost every time. **Clarity beats clever. Alignment beats volume. Build the machine. Then the machine builds momentum.**

Where do you stand?	10 questions, 2 minutes, your signal score and what to fix first.	**frdtlab.com/scorecard**
Want the how-to?	Get Recommended by AI: The GEO Playbook. The confidence engine, the 7 levers, a 30-day plan. $97.	**frdtlab.com/geo-playbook**
Want it built with you?	Advisory, workshops, and speaking.	**frdtlab.com/work-with-me**
Enter the Lab.	The research drop, in your inbox.	**afrdtlab.substack.com**